










ART

# THE PAIN OF OTHERS

***Somnath Hore*** was a great artist of collective hope and hardship, but his abiding legacy is to make us feel each human tragedy as our own

What makes someone become an artist? Somnath Hore, who would have been 101 this summer, was first moved to draw in December 1942 by a moment of violence: the Japanese bombing of a village called Patia in what is now Bangladesh. Hore was then a B.Sc. student at City College in Calcutta, but World War II evacuation had forced him to return to his Chittagong home. The ghastly sight of Patia's dead and wounded seemed to demand recording in some way, and it was images to which the young man turned.

In Calcutta, he had begun to design posters for the Communist Party, but it was Chittagong that really put Hore on his political and artistic path. Two things happened in 1943: the Bengal famine began, and Hore met Chittaprosad. Six years Hore's senior and also from Chittagong, Chittaprosad was already a prolific artist documenting the lives of Bengal's rural poor. As a man-made colonial tragedy killed millions around them, Chittaprosad encouraged Hore to draw portraits of the hungry, sick and dying. "From morning to evening I used to accompany him on his rounds," Hore wrote later. "He initiated me into directly sketching the people I saw on streets and hospitals."

In 1945, Hore enrolled for formal art training at the Government College of Art and Craft. In 1946, the Communist party sent him off to Tebhaga in North Bengal, where he created a diary-like documentation of the massive peasant protests. It was a tumultuous decade, moving between politics and art while having to make a living by teaching school students art. When the government again banned the Communist party, he went underground. It was not until 1957-58 that Hore got his diploma, and left Calcutta and politics to become a lecturer at the future Delhi College of Art.

The visceral realism of Somnath Hore's early works gives way to abstraction and greater economy of line

The show at Delhi's Kiran Nadar Museum of Art is superb; its gravitas undimmed by ill-advised curatorial versifying: sample *"He witnessed as a child a world not so fair,/ Disparities between rich and poor had no compare...."* It's clear that Hore experimented with form and material through